X CAMPAIGN KIT · VANCOUVER CIVIC ELECTION · OCTOBER 17, 2026

The Freeway Vancouver Never Built

Two X Articles, a timed thread, and posting notes. The history goes out tonight; the future follows the results.



Huge log at Georgia and Seymour streets, 1886. Photo: J.A. Brock. City of Vancouver Archives, CVA Tr P13. Public domain.

Nonpartisan: no candidates or parties are named. Free (unpaid) posts only. Only public-domain archival photographs are used. Prepared October 16, 2026.

Posting schedule

All times Pacific. General Voting Day is Saturday, October 17, 2026. Polls close at 8 PM.

WHEN	WHAT	ASSET
Fri Oct 16, before 6:30 PM	Publish X Article 1 (history)	Article 1; 1886 Georgia & Seymour photo
Fri Oct 16, 6:30 PM	Thread wave 1 (posts 1–4)	Post 2: 1886 photo; final post quotes Article 1
Fri Oct 16, 8:30 PM	Thread wave 2 (posts 5–9)	Text only; final post quotes Article 1
Sat Oct 17, 7–9 AM	“Before you vote” post	Text only (nonpartisan get-out-the-vote)
Sat Oct 17, 5–8 PM	Peak post (polls close 8 PM)	Felling large timber, North Arm of the Fraser River, ca. 1890 (CVA 677-243)
After results are called	Publish X Article 2 (future), then post-results post	Article 2; North Arm Fraser River timber photo, ca. 1890

Thread and post copy

Character counts are approximate X counts (emoji count as 2). Every post is under 280 characters. Check every fact against the Articles before posting.

TONIGHT 6:30 PM PT: WAVE 1

1/
Vancouver is the only major North American city with no freeway into its downtown. That's because residents of Chinatown and Strathcona fought the bulldozers in 1967. Tomorrow's vote shapes what we do with that advantage. Here's the story 🧵 #VanPoli

250 chars · No image, no link.

2/
In the 1960s, plans linked to the Project 200 waterfront scheme put a freeway along the downtown waterfront and through Chinatown. Strathcona homes were already being cleared for "urban renewal," and Hogan's Alley, the heart of Vancouver's Black community, was being levelled.

276 chars · Image: Huge log at Georgia & Seymour, 1886 (J.A. Brock, CVA Tr P13, public domain).

3/
Chinatown and Strathcona survived. Hogan's Alley mostly didn't. What gets built on the ground they saved is still being decided.

128 chars · No image.

4/
The full story, from the 1967 "Great Freeway Debate" at city hall to the viaducts still standing today, is in my Article ↓

122 chars · Quote-post the history Article.

TONIGHT 8:30 PM PT: WAVE 2

5/
Nov. 23, 1967: more than 500 people packed Vancouver city hall over the Chinatown freeway. The Province called it the "wildest, most stormy meeting ever seen at city hall." The Chinatown route was dropped in 1968. #VanPoli

222 chars · No image.

6/
In 1968, Strathcona residents formed SPOTA, starting at Mary Lee Chan and Walter Chan's kitchen table on Keefer Street. Door-knocking, block captains and a case taken to Ottawa helped halt federal urban-renewal funding.

219 chars · No image (Chan family photos are not cleared).

7/

1972: more than 21,000 people signed a petition against a third Burrard Inlet crossing and its feeder freeways. By year's end the freeway plan was dead.

152 chars · No image.

8/

The only pieces ever built: the Georgia and Dunsmuir viaducts (1971–72). Hogan's Alley was largely lost to them. Council voted in 2015 to remove them. They're still standing, and the City says the timeline is uncertain.

219 chars · No image. Do not use the 1970–71 viaduct photos (under copyright).

9/

What grew instead: the seawall, False Creek neighbourhoods, SkyTrain, a walkable downtown. Whoever you vote for, it's worth asking: what do we build next? Full story ↓

167 chars · Quote-post the history Article.

TOMORROW 7–9 AM PT: BEFORE YOU VOTE

Post

Vancouver votes today. In 1967 and 1968, ordinary residents showed up at city hall and changed this city's direction. Today it takes one ballot. Check the City of Vancouver's election page for your voting place. #VanPoli #VanVotes

230 chars · Free post only (no boost). Nonpartisan get-out-the-vote.

TOMORROW 5–8 PM PT: PEAK (POLLS CLOSE 8 PM)

Post

Polls close at 8 PM. The freeway that would have cut through Chinatown was stopped by neighbours who showed up. Whatever your choice, show up today. #VanPoli #VanVotes

167 chars · Image: Felling large timber, North Arm of the Fraser River, ca. 1890. Bailey Bros. City of Vancouver Archives, CVA 677-243.

AFTER RESULTS

Post

The votes are counted. Whoever won, the same questions are waiting: the viaducts, the Broadway Subway (opening fall 2027), housing, the waterfront, Stanley Park's forest. Here's a look at Vancouver's next 50 years ↓ #VanPoli

224 chars · Link or quote the future Article.

X ARTICLE 1 · HISTORY · PUBLISH TONIGHT

The Freeway Vancouver Never Built

How residents of Chinatown and Strathcona changed the course of a city



Huge log at Georgia and Seymour streets, 1886. Photo: J.A. Brock. City of Vancouver Archives, CVA Tr P13. Public domain.

If you drive into downtown Vancouver from the east, Highway 1 bends away at the city's edge. No ramp lifts you onto an elevated expressway. You end up on Hastings or Main at a red light, next to a bus and a cyclist.

That isn't an oversight. Vancouver is the only major city in North America without a freeway running into its downtown. Cities elsewhere in the world, such as Amsterdam, also kept motorways out of their historic centres. But on this continent, almost every big city was carved up by expressways after the Second World War. Vancouver wasn't, and that happened because residents fought it.

A city drawn for cars

Vancouver's first comprehensive plan, by Harland Bartholomew and Associates in 1928–29, called for wider arterials and scenic "pleasure drives." It didn't call for freeways. Those came in the 1950s. Gerald Sutton-Brown, the city's first director of

planning and later one of its powerful appointed commissioners, chaired the committee that produced a 1959 master freeway plan.

By 1967, the Vancouver Transportation Study, prepared by San Francisco consultants, had worked out the details. An elevated freeway would run along the downtown waterfront, then swing through Gastown's Maple Tree Square and the heart of Chinatown before heading east along Prior Street. A rebuilt Georgia Viaduct would feed traffic into downtown. The plan tied in with Project 200, a huge Canadian Pacific Railway scheme of towers and plazas on the waterfront, and with a proposed third crossing of Burrard Inlet near Brockton Point.

The neighbourhood in the way

The freeway route ran through Strathcona, the city's oldest residential neighbourhood, where Chinese, Italian, Japanese, Ukrainian and Black families lived. The City had been preparing the ground for years. A 1931 bylaw zoned much of the East End as industrial. The City's 1957 redevelopment study listed Strathcona among the areas most in need of redevelopment. The City now acknowledges that during the 1950s and 1960s it stopped issuing building permits there and let the infrastructure decline.

Clearance began around 1960. Whole blocks came down to make way for the MacLean Park towers and the Raymur housing project. Thousands of people were displaced across the phases.

Residents fought back early. In 1971 a group of mothers from the Raymur project, who became known as the Militant Mothers of Raymur, blockaded the rail line their children had to cross to get to school, and they won a pedestrian overpass at Keefer Street.

Hogan's Alley, the informal name for Park Lane and the blocks around it, was the heart of Vancouver's Black community. It was home to the Fountain Chapel, to chicken houses like Vie's, and to Nora Hendrix, Jimi Hendrix's grandmother. From 1967, the City began levelling its western half for the viaduct project. In the City's own words, the displacement was "finalized by the construction of the Georgia and Dunsmuir viaducts in 1972."

The night city hall erupted

On June 1, 1967, council moved to accept a first freeway segment through Chinatown. Chinese merchants, local architects and Alderman Harry Rankin pushed for public hearings. At those hearings it emerged that the consultants had never been asked to consider any route other than the one through Chinatown.

On November 23, 1967, more than 500 people crowded into city hall for what the press called the "Great Freeway Debate." The Province's Bud Elsie called it the "wildest, most stormy meeting ever seen at city hall." When the hearing continued at Eric Hamber Secondary, Peter Oberlander, head of UBC's planning school, resigned as chair of the Town Planning Commission. "Planning is too serious a matter to leave solely to professional civic officials," he said. The Chinatown route was dropped in 1968.

A kitchen table on Keefer Street

Strathcona residents organized as well. In 1968 they formed the Strathcona Property Owners and Tenants Association (SPOTA), which the Vancouver Heritage Foundation says drew more than 600 members. It started at the kitchen table of Mary Lee Chan and Walter Chan, 658 Keefer Street. Mary and her daughter Shirley Chan went door to door. Harry Con, Walter Chan and Sue Lum were elected co-presidents. Bessie Lee pushed to recruit non-Chinese neighbours, and block captains carried the news house to house.

SPOTA took its case all the way to Ottawa. After Mary Chan met federal minister Paul Hellyer, federal funding for urban renewal was frozen, and the city couldn't pay for the next phase of clearance. SPOTA then argued that renewal money should be used to repair homes rather than bulldoze them. The idea became a model for a national rehabilitation program, and in 1975 the Strathcona rehabilitation won the Vincent Massey Award for Excellence in the Urban Environment.

The last battle

The freeway's final chance was the third crossing. In December 1971, council voted 6–5 to fund the approach routes. By February 1972, a Citizens' Committee for Public Transit had collected more than 21,000 signatures, and federal ministers were backing away. By the end of 1972, the crossing and its feeder freeways were dead.

Civic politics changed with them. The Electors' Action Movement (TEAM), which grew out of the 1967 hearings, won the mayoralty and eight of ten council seats in December 1972, ending decades of Non-Partisan Association control. Art Phillips became mayor. UBC geographer Walter Hardwick, a longtime critic of the freeway plans, was among TEAM's leaders.

The fragment still standing

The Georgia and Dunsmuir viaducts opened in 1971 and 1972. They are the only parts of the freeway system that were ever built. Council voted to remove them on October

27, 2015, and approved the Northeast False Creek Plan in 2018, which would replace them with ordinary streets, parks and housing.

They are still standing. Funding depends on redevelopment that has stalled, and the City says the removal timeline "is still uncertain." Repair crews are working on the Georgia Viaduct this fall.

What other cities paid

Look south and east for the alternative. Seattle ran I-5 through its downtown and lived for decades with the elevated Alaskan Way Viaduct along its waterfront. The viaduct closed in 2019 and was replaced by a tunnel. Toronto cancelled the Spadina Expressway in 1971, but the Gardiner still separates its downtown from the lake. Boston's Big Dig cost enormous sums to bury an elevated highway. San Francisco tore down its Embarcadero Freeway only after the 1989 earthquake damaged it. Vancouver got most of what those cities later paid to win back, without first building a freeway and then tearing it down.

What grew instead

Without expressways emptying downtown every evening, Vancouver had reasons to make living downtown appealing. The city became known for slim towers set on townhouse podiums. False Creek's industrial shores turned into neighbourhoods. The seawall now runs 28 kilometres from the Convention Centre to Spanish Banks. SkyTrain opened in 1985–86, and the City's 1997 Transportation Plan put walking first and cars last.

There have been trade-offs. Housing costs are among the highest on the continent, traffic and growth spilled out to the suburbs, and Highway 1 still carries the region's heavy loads along its edge.

But this was a choice made by people: Mary Lee Chan and her neighbours, a crowd packed into city hall on a November night, and 21,000 people who signed a petition. They didn't think of themselves as urban theorists. They were defending their homes and their right to be consulted.

The freeway fight is over. What Vancouver builds on the ground it saved is still being decided.

X ARTICLE 2 · FUTURE · PUBLISH AFTER RESULTS

The City That Kept Its Options Open

Vancouver's next fifty years, and the advantage few North American cities have

Most big North American cities spend their future paying for their past. Seattle replaced the Alaskan Way Viaduct with a tunnel, Boston paid for the Big Dig, and Toronto is still arguing over the Gardiner. A great deal of urban ambition on this continent goes into undoing the expressway era.

Vancouver is the only major North American city without a freeway into its core, so it carries less of that debt. Its waterfront is largely public. Its grid is fine-grained and laced with back lanes. Walking and transit already carry a large share of daily life. That doesn't guarantee a good future, but it does leave the city more room to manoeuvre than almost any of its peers.

The votes are now counted. Whoever is sitting at the council table, the questions below will be waiting. The facts in this piece reflect the public record as of October 2026. Wherever I imagine what comes next, I say so.

Finishing the story: the viaducts

The Georgia and Dunsmuir viaducts are the only pieces of the old freeway plan ever built. Council voted in 2015 to remove them. The 2018 Northeast False Creek Plan would replace them with an at-grade street network, 32 acres of new and renewed parks and open space, and about 1,800 units of social housing. The plan also builds in reconciliation with local First Nations and redress for the Black and Chinese Canadian communities, including a City memorandum of understanding with the Hogan's Alley Society for the 898 Main Street block.

As of this month, the viaducts are still standing, and the City says the removal timeline "is still uncertain." Funding depends on redevelopment that has stalled because of a weak condo market and rising costs. Concord Pacific's 2025 Concord Landing concept proposed about 5,000 homes in 12 towers. The City is talking with senior governments about financing. In the meantime, crews are repairing the Georgia Viaduct's expansion joints through spring 2027.

Speculation: the land is too valuable and the structures too old for the viaducts to stand forever. The real question is what replaces them. One option is simply more towers by the water. A better one would knit together Chinatown, Strathcona, the stadiums, Science World and a revived Hogan's Alley block with ordinary streets. The last

remnant of the freeway era would then become a neighbourhood that openly acknowledges what happened there.

Transit: the Broadway Subway and beyond

The Broadway Subway is a 5.7-kilometre extension of the Millennium Line from VCC–Clark to Arbutus, with six underground stations. Its trackwork was finished in September 2026, and it is scheduled to open in fall 2027. The province says it will carry three times as many people as the 99 B-Line.

A roughly seven-kilometre extension to UBC is in planning, but as of this autumn it has no full construction funding. TransLink is also studying rapid transit to the North Shore, possibly with a dedicated transit crossing. Half a century after Vancouverites killed a freeway tunnel near Brockton Point, the third-crossing debate is now about moving people rather than adding lanes into downtown.

A connected region

Vancouver doesn't stand alone. The city's freeway-free core works because the whole region is tied together by transit, and that network is still growing.

The backbone already exists. The Expo Line runs from Waterfront through Burnaby and New Westminster to Surrey. The Millennium Line serves Burnaby and the Tri-Cities as far as Lafarge Lake–Douglas in Coquitlam. The Canada Line connects downtown to Richmond and YVR. The 16-kilometre Surrey–Langley extension, recently named the Dave Barrett Extension, is under construction along Fraser Highway. It will have eight stations and is expected to open in late 2029. Once it opens, Langley City Centre will have a direct SkyTrain connection to downtown Vancouver.

The water is part of the network. The SeaBus has crossed Burrard Inlet since 1977. Its newest vessel, the Burrard Chinook, entered service in 2021 as Canada's first fully hybrid-electric SeaBus, and TransLink is designing a battery-electric next-generation vessel.

From here on, this section is speculation. Imagine electric passenger ferries linking a ring of waterfront nodes: Horseshoe Bay and the North Shore, Port Moody and Deep Cove up the inlet, and New Westminster, Ladner and Steveston on the Fraser. Waterways that now divide the region could become some of its quietest, most reliable routes.

Tunnels for transit, not for cars. *This is speculative, and nobody has proposed it.* Picture a dense mesh rather than a few big trunk lines: many small-bore tunnels and many surface portals. Robotaxis and autonomous TransLink shuttles would run point to

point beneath busy arterials, then come up close to where people actually want to go, whether a school in Newton, a clinic in Kerrisdale or a ferry dock in Ladner. SkyTrain would remain the backbone. The mesh would handle the in-between trips, the ones that now push people into cars.

This wouldn't bring back the freeway by another route. It would be the next step after the freeway fight. The 1967 plan would have pushed private cars through neighbourhoods at the cost of homes and waterfront. A mesh like this would carry shared, electric, automated vehicles under neighbourhoods and leave the surface for people.

The engineering constraints are real. Whether a mesh like this is even feasible is an open question, for at least four reasons:

- **Soft, wet ground.** Much of Richmond and Delta sits on Fraser River delta sediments. In a geotechnical memo for the Massey crossing, engineers describe a water table "close to grade" and a top layer of sand, roughly 30 metres thick, that can liquefy in an earthquake. They also note that a deep soft-ground bored tunnel there would be at "the current upper boundaries" of tunnel-boring technology.
- **Earthquakes.** Every tunnel in the region has to be designed for seismic shaking. The seismic retrofit of the George Massey Tunnel is a reminder of how much work that takes in delta soils.
- **Water crossings.** The routes across Burrard Inlet and the Fraser are the hardest and most expensive kind of tunnelling. Metro Vancouver's Port Mann water supply tunnel under the Fraser ran into groundwater pressure that its engineers called the highest of any soft-ground tunnel in Canada at the time.
- **No precedent at this scale.** The Boring Company's only operating system, the Vegas Loop, currently lists 14 stations. It runs under the dry ground of the Las Vegas resort corridor, and a 2026 report put the tunnels in active use at about 3.5 miles. That is far smaller and geologically simpler than a region-wide mesh in Metro Vancouver.

Cost, safety, capacity, and whether autonomous vehicles mature as promised are all unanswered questions too. Treat the mesh as something worth studying, not something to count on.

The waterfront and the rising sea

The City counts 28 kilometres of uninterrupted seawall, and Vancouver's public waterfront is rare among big cities. It is also vulnerable. The City plans for about one metre of sea-level rise by 2100 and two metres by 2200, and parts of the False Creek

seawall already face overtopping at high tide. The City's False Creek Coastal Adaptation Plan pairs near-term shoreline protection with nature-based measures such as habitat benches, forest berms and "blue-green" corridors, and over time it would move vulnerable development back from the edge.

Speculation: this could become the next defining Vancouver idea, a shoreline built to flood gracefully. A city that turned down one kind of hard infrastructure in 1972 might do best by turning down the easiest hard-engineering answer again.

Stanley Park: growing old growth on purpose



Felling large timber, North Arm of the Fraser River, ca. 1890. Bailey Bros. City of Vancouver Archives, CVA 677-243. Logging of this kind cleared much of the region’s original forest, including Stanley Park’s, in the late 1800s.

One of the most important long-term projects in the city is happening at the scale of seedlings. This isn't logging. It is targeted removal of hazard trees, followed by a deliberately diverse replanting.

What happened. The hemlock looper is a native moth whose populations surge roughly every 15 years. It hit Stanley Park hard in an outbreak first identified in 2020. Drought and hard winters had already weakened the trees, and the outbreak lasted longer than usual. According to the City's Stanley Park forest management page, about 160,000 of the park's roughly 600,000 trees are dead or dying. Most of them are western hemlock, which the City notes had become over-represented after past

logging and windstorms and is more prone than other conifers to disease, windthrow and stem breakage.

Why remove dead trees at all? The case rests on safety. The Park Board's impact and wildfire risk assessment expected dead trees to shed tops and branches, and to fail entirely, over the next two decades. As they did, dry fuel would build up on the forest floor. It classified 24 per cent of the park as high or extreme wildfire risk and another 60 per cent as moderate, and it warned that standing dead trees make emergency response harder and more dangerous. A 2024 Park Board report warned that an untreated forest could face "a devastating fire that would not only affect Stanley Park, but potentially the region."

Targeted, not wholesale. Only a fraction of the dead trees are being cut, mainly those near trails, roads and high-use areas. The City's rounded headline figure is about 14,000 trees removed. Its phase-by-phase totals add up to roughly 11,500. It also reports that 71 per cent of the park's forested areas have been treated. The Park Board's July 2025 update says no old-growth trees were removed and that work takes place from October to April, outside bird nesting season. Not everything cut is hauled away. Topped snags are left as wildlife habitat, and some felled trees stay on the ground as nurse logs and coarse woody debris. Fir, cedar and other cultural wood has gone to the Musqueam, Squamish and Tsleil-Waututh Nations for longhouse and ceremonial use. Most hemlock was sold or left on site. The January 2026 update notes that Park Board staff supported planting events with the Squamish and Tsleil-Waututh Nations. The final stage, which includes the trails around Beaver Lake, resumed this October and is expected to finish in spring 2027.

A more diverse forest. More than 75,000 seedlings have been planted so far, supported by a three-year donation from Western Forest Products. The 2024 Park Board report anticipated nearly 100,000 by the time the work is complete. The planting uses six native species: western redcedar, Douglas-fir, Sitka spruce, grand fir, red alder and Pacific yew. The goal, in the City's words, is a forest "more resilient to future insect outbreaks and climate change impacts." A mixed forest also spreads the risk. The next looper outbreak will find far less of the hemlock it prefers.

Why this could speed up the path to old growth. Portions of the forest were logged from the 1860s into the 1880s, according to the Park Board's restoration plan. Major windstorms in the 1930s, Typhoon Freda in 1962 and a storm in 2006 brought down more. Most of today's park is second growth. True old growth survives in one small remnant stand near Tunnel Trail and Pipeline Road, according to the Park Board's Forest Management Plan, along with veteran trees scattered through the park. Ecologically, old growth means more than old trees. The BC government describes large trees of varied sizes, species and ages, layered canopies with openings, and

plenty of standing dead and decaying wood. A dense stand of same-aged hemlock is a long way from that.

Canopy gaps and mixed planting are a recognized way to close that distance. In western Washington, the U.S. Forest Service's Olympic Habitat Development Study tested "thinning with skips and gaps" in 40- to 70-year-old conifer stands to see whether it could speed up the development of late-successional structure. After 14 years, researchers found faster growth and longer crowns in mid-story trees and more recruitment of shade-tolerant species. They did not find consistent gains among the largest trees or in overall size diversity. The direction is encouraging, but the evidence is still accumulating.

How much time could this save? It's tempting to say this work could bring old growth back in about 300 years instead of 400 to 500. No source I found puts a number of years saved on active management, for Stanley Park or anywhere else, so treat that as a hypothesis. The best local benchmark comes from a Vancouver Island study in the same coastal western hemlock zone. It found that second-growth stands reached old-growth structural levels in as little as 112 years, but most took 200 to more than 250 years. Research on restoration thinning in the Pacific Northwest, such as this review, reports that it can speed up the development of old-growth characteristics. The honest summary: targeted removal and diverse planting push the forest in the right direction, and how many decades they save is uncertain. The structural qualities that make a forest feel ancient, including big cedars and firs, a layered canopy and a mix of species, depend heavily on what grows in the gaps now. Today's work is the main lever people have over that.

None of this timeline is guaranteed. But if Stanley Park does grow big cedars again, they will not have arrived by accident. They will descend from seedlings planted in the gaps between 2024 and 2027.

Biodiversity: a city that shares its edges

The freeway-free waterfront also turned out to be a gift to wildlife. Stanley Park is home to one of the largest urban great blue heron colonies in North America, according to the Park Board's Biodiversity Strategy. The herons have nested near the Park Board office at 2099 Beach Avenue since 2001, and in the park since at least 1921. In 2025, Stanley Park Ecology's monitoring report counted about 100 nests and recorded the colony's 25th consecutive year at that site. The Pacific great blue heron is blue-listed in BC, and the same strategy warns that many native birds, including several shorebirds and forest species, are declining.

The policy tools already exist. The 2016 Biodiversity Strategy guides restoration of natural areas. The 2025 Urban Forest Strategy aims to raise citywide tree canopy

from 25 per cent to 30 per cent by 2050. The False Creek adaptation work includes habitat benches along the shoreline.

Speculation: if the city treats its seawall, its streams and the mixed-species forest of Stanley Park as one connected habitat network, Vancouver could become one of the few big North American cities where wildlife has more room in 2075 than it had in 1975.

Density without sprawl

A city without freeways needs people living close to where they go. The Broadway Plan, approved in 2022 and updated in 2024, is a 30-year framework for housing and jobs along the subway. Multiplex zoning, approved in 2023, allows more homes on lots in low-density neighbourhoods that once allowed little more than a single house. *If these policies work*, the Vancouver of 2050 could have broad walkable areas of mid-rise apartments and multiplexes, with towers clustered at transit nodes, and growth would happen inside the city rather than at the region's edges.

Indigenous-led city-building

Some of the most consequential development ahead is being led by the Musqueam, Squamish and Tsleil-Waututh Nations.

Seȟáḵw, on Squamish Nation reserve land at the Burrard Bridge, welcomed its first residents this year. The first phase is about 1,400 rental homes in three towers, and the full plan calls for 11 towers and more than 6,000 rental homes.

The Jericho Lands, about 90 acres in West Point Grey owned by the MST Nations and Canada Lands Company, received an Official Development Plan in April 2025 for roughly 13,000 homes over about 25 years. The first phased rezoning is still to come.

The Heather Lands received a revised rezoning in March 2026 for about 4,200 homes, most of them intended to be sold below market through a provincial program.

My reading: these projects plan across generations, on land that was never ceded. In 1972 Vancouver became "the city that stopped the freeway." By 2072 it might also be known as the city its host Nations helped rebuild.

The risks

Affordability comes first. A walkable, transit-rich waterfront city is exactly the kind of place people pay a premium for.

Poorly done density is the second. Taller towers without enough schools, parks, childcare and street life would waste the opportunity.

Losing what makes the city special is the third. The open waterfront, the views and the sense that neighbourhoods have a say can wear away through a thousand individually reasonable decisions.

Pressure on the region is the last. Burnaby, Surrey and the bridges still carry much of the region's growth and traffic. A fair future recognizes that.

An opportunity, not an inheritance

Vancouver has rare advantages, but they won't defend themselves. The freeway wasn't stopped by luck. It was stopped by neighbours who knocked on doors and showed up at city hall. The next fifty years will need the same attention to rent, transit, the shoreline and who gets to live here. The city avoided a mistake once, and it still has to decide what to build on the ground it saved.

Sources

IMAGES

- J.A. Brock, “Huge log at Georgia and Seymour streets,” 1886. City of Vancouver Archives, CVA Tr P13. Public domain.
- Bailey Bros., “Felling large timber – North Arm Fraser River near Vancouver, B.C. – George Oliver’s contrac t,” ca. 1890. City of Vancouver Archives, CVA 677-243. https://searcharchives.vancouver.ca/856-felling-larg e-timber-north-arm-fraser-river-near-vancouver-b-c-george-olivers-contract

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